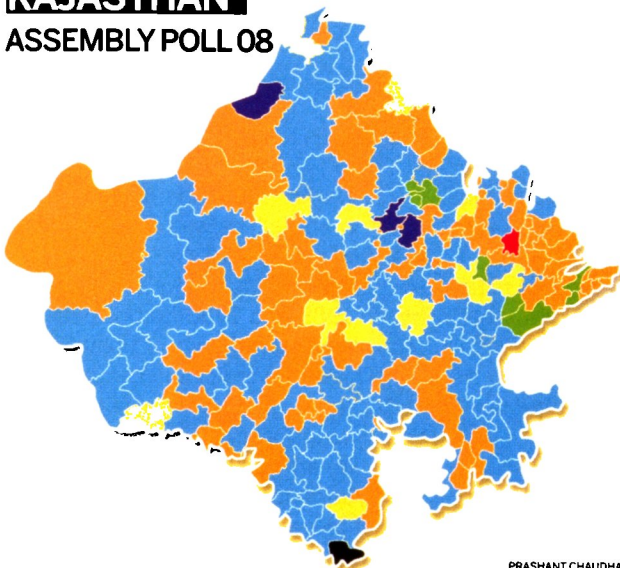


## RAJASTHAN

ASSEMBLY POLL 08



PRASHANT CHAUDHARY

| RESULT   | 2008 | 2003 |
|----------|------|------|
| ■ CONG   | 96   | 56   |
| ■ BJP    | 78   | 120  |
| ■ BSP    | 6    | 2    |
| ■ INLD   | 0    | 4    |
| ■ JD (U) | 1    | 2    |
| ■ CPI(M) | 3    | 1    |
| OTHERS   | 16   | 15   |

Total number of seats: 200

# 140

is the number of rallies that Gehlot addressed, twice as many as Raje.

# 16

candidates had victory margins less than 1,000, an indication of how close the contest was.

**Vasundhara Raje's frequent visits to seven districts dominated by tribals or Gujjars failed to yield the desired result.**



PURUSHOTTAM DWAKAR

ruption did not influence voters. Raje, on the other hand, knew what could please people and make them swing in her favour. So in tribal areas where home-brewed illicit liquor flows freely, she decided to withdraw more than 20,000 petty cases, often registered for making such liquor and then creating public nuisance—her thanksgiving gesture for their large-scale support to her party in the previous polls. This, however, did not fetch her a seat in seven districts, mostly dominated by tribals or Gujjars. Even her frequent visits and claims of development failed to yield the desired result.

The Congress also targeted Raje's inability to keep public outrage under control in sensitive situations like police firing on tribals in Udaipur division. As Gehlot said soon after the election results: "People voted out an insensitive government." He hit out at her incompetence when Gujjar agitators were crushed ruthlessly and police fired on Left-backed farmers agitating for water which saw the CPI(M) win three seats. The Meenas, who opposed reservations for Gujjars, voted heavily against the BJP. Their anger was also fuelled by the party's inability to retain Kirori Lal Meena, who revolted against party state President Om Prakash Mathur. Both Meena and his wife

won, so have his supporters. Meena proved to be a powerful rebel but otherwise, both the BJP and Congress had only six rebels who won. Both the parties appeared to have suffered equally also at the hands of BSP which got more than 7 per cent of the total vote share across the state after fielding candidates in all 200 seats and winning six. Sixteen candidates could win just by a margin of less than 1,000.

In the end, it appears the Congress managed its rebels in a better way than BJP. It started finalising the names early and completed it earlier than the BJP. The tussle over candidates within the saffron party went on for so long that Raje, who was to launch her campaign by September-end, could not start it until third week of November. Since many names were released just on the last day of nominations, the party was left with no time to accommodate strong rebels by shuffling a few. It even lost advantage of knowing Congress candidates in advance. Consequently, most BJP veterans either remained indifferent or sabotaged the party's electoral prospects.

The Congress, however, did not face that problem as